

“ A noisome, squat, and nameless animal ... **not a proper model** for an American senator.”

SENATOR CHARLES SUMNER ON SENATOR STEPHEN DOUGLAS IN HIS
“CRIME AGAINST KANSAS SPEECH,” MAY 19-20, 1856

The Lecompton Constitution

Their idea was to give voters in Kansas a referendum between their own Lecompton Constitution “with slavery” or a “future” free state “without slavery.” In the latter case, the 200 slaves in Kansas would remain in bondage as would any children they bore, but there would be no extension of slavery beyond that.

While Republicans and free-state supporters denounced the plan, it put severe strains on the Democratic Party. Across the North, Democrats faced a dilemma. They knew that backing the Lecompton Constitution would be seen as a betrayal of the ideal of popular sovereignty and too sympathetic to Southern interests. On the other hand, opposing the constitution would alienate the Southern Democrats, the party’s most powerful group in Congress.

Four years earlier, Stephen Douglas had promised the voters of Kansas the right to decide about slavery in a free and fair election. In 1858, he rose in the Senate to denounce the Lecompton Constitution, even as a new president, Democrat James Buchanan, urged its acceptance. Southern senators ostracized Douglas and made it clear he would never have their support for a future presidential run. In Kansas, meanwhile, federal troops monitored the vote as citizens overwhelmingly rejected slavery. In Congressional elections, Northern voters swept most pro-Southern Democrats from office.